

TREATMENT

Therapy should be individualized for each patient and involves more than simple wound management. Pressure ulcers are frequently a clinical sign of underlying medical conditions that should be treated to facilitate healing. Few controlled trials have evaluated specific treatment modalities for pressure ulcers. The general principles of therapy for pressure ulcers are the following.

Relief of Pressure, Shear, and Frictional Forces

POSITIONING

Positioning techniques are critical in the management of tissue loads.

While in bed, patients should be positioned to avoid pressure over existing ulcers or over bony prominences, especially the trochanter. Pillows or foam wedges can be used to lift a pressure ulcer off its support surface or to prevent direct contact between bony prominences, such as knees or ankles. It is important to limit the amount of time the head of the bed is elevated and to maintain the head of the bed at the lowest possible level of elevation tolerable to reduce shearing forces at sacral tissues. Immobilized patients are usually placed in a 30° oblique position to the left or right, which should be alternated every 2 hours at a minimum.

The patient and caregivers must learn appropriate transfer or mobilization techniques to avoid friction. The patient should be lifted rather than dragged across the bedsheets, using lifting devices such as a trapeze or bed linen. Repositioning should be done as frequently as warranted by the patient's condition.

Moisture from urinary or fecal incontinence, perspiration, or wound drainage should be minimized, and the skin should be kept clean. Absorbent underpads, briefs, diapers, and occasionally urinary catheters or rectal tubes may be

required to help manage incontinence. Skin barrier creams can help protect the skin from maceration.

Patients who are sitting may select a pressure-relieving cushion based on specific needs. Donut-type devices should be avoided because they result in venous congestion and may worsen ulcers. Patients should be encouraged to reposition themselves frequently.

SUPPORT SURFACES

Support surfaces can be used on top of or instead of standard mattresses.